renew and defend the democratic values that define our nationhood that we will be able to face the great challenges that lie before us.' [16]

Such pronouncements are not just the 'feel good' avowals of leaders trying to rally their people. In India's case, they reflect a deep-seated way of thinking almost identical to the messianic vision of the United States. It has repeatedly manifested itself in India's policies.

As India has become more globally connected and integrated, Indian exceptionalism has not diminished. In fact, it even lives on among the vast Indian diaspora, including second and third-generation non-resident Indians (i.e. immigrants to other countries). Conversations and interviews with politicians, civil servants, scholars and diplomats over the last decade reflect a continuing sense of destiny and sense of India's specialness. Like others who believe in national uniqueness and manifest destiny, Indians tend to stick to what they see as their principles and not give up on them as part of a compromise. An Indian diplomat remarked to this author in an interview that India needed to do things not simply because they were beneficial to India but because it was the right thing to do. Thus, compromises for self-interest are often looked down upon, and when they are made, a veneer of high-minded principle is maintained.

While India aspires for global great power status, in its immediate neighbourhood it already considers itself one. India's immediate neighbourhood – South Asia – is India's backyard where it does not like the interference of other major powers. The greater neighbourhood, extending from the Gulf to South-East Asia, is also part of India's sphere of influence, and developments in the region are deemed critical to India's foreign and security policy. As President Pranab Mukherjee observed in his annual address to the joint session of parliament in 2013, India seeks 'peace, stability, cooperation and economic development' in South Asia and attaches 'the highest priority to relations with our immediate neighbours'.[17]

